

But there is a more basic problem with the process view. Hort saw clearly, and correctly, that the Majority Text must have a common archetype. Recall that Hort's genealogical method was based on community of **error**. On the hypothesis that the Majority Text is a late and inferior text form, the large mass of common readings which distinguish it from the so-called 'Western' or 'Alexandrian text-types' must be **errors** (which was precisely Hort's contention) and such an agreement in error would have to have a common source. The process view fails completely to account for such an agreement in error (on that hypothesis).

Hort saw the need for a common source and posited a Lucianic revision. Scholars now generally recognize that the 'Byzantine text-type' must date back at least into the second century. But what chance would the original 'Byzantine' document, the archetype, have of gaining currency when appeal to the Autographs was still possible (if it was a separate invention)?

Candidly, there is only one reasonable explanation for the Majority Text that has so far been advanced—it is the result of an essentially normal process of transmission and the common source for its consensus is the Autographs. Down through the centuries of copying, the original text has always been reflected with a high degree of accuracy in the manuscript tradition as a whole. The history of the text presented above not only accounts nicely for the Majority Text, it also accounts for the inconsistent minority of MSS. They are remnants of the abnormal transmission of the text, reflecting ancient aberrant forms. It is a dependence upon such aberrant forms that distinguishes contemporary critical/eclectic editions of the Greek New Testament, and the modern translations based upon them.

What Is the Actual Evidence?

What is the actual evidence that needs to be evaluated? The continuous text MSS are the primary witnesses. The Lectionaries are secondary witnesses. The ancient Versions and patristic citations are tertiary witnesses. Any historical evidence, to the extent that it can be verified, is ancillary. The relevance of the secondary and tertiary types of evidence depends upon the presuppositions that the original wording was lost, and that the transmission of the text was not normal. Since both those presuppositions are false, I will confine my attention to the primary witnesses, the more so since there are so many of them.

The primary witnesses are customarily treated as being of three types: the papyri, the uncials and the cursives. The papyri and the uncials are both written with upper case letters (often without spacing between words), the difference being in the material used, papyrus or parchment (leather). The